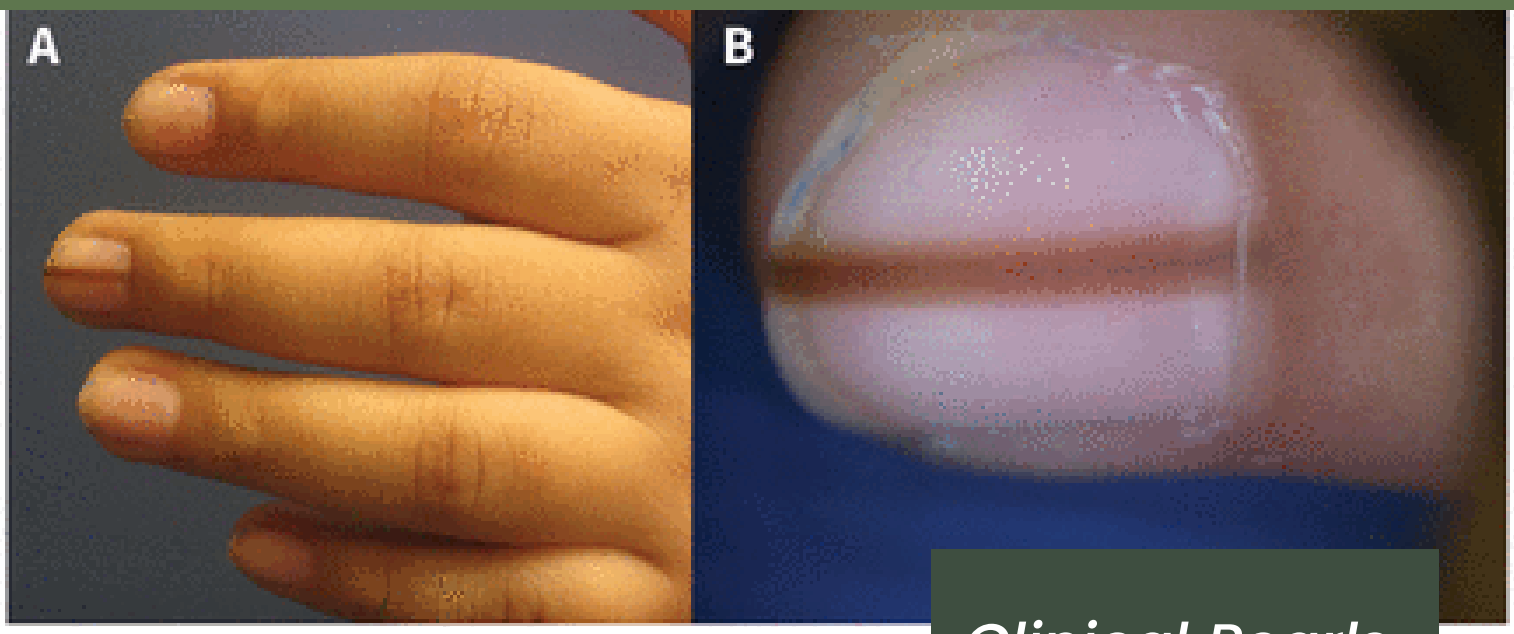
Notes from Benchmark

Clinical Pearls • New Evidence • Interesting Cases

Benchmark Diagnostics

Vol 1 | Issue 1 | January 2026

Pediatric Longitudinal Melanonychia: Less Alarm, More Observation



Pediatric Longitudinal Melanonychia:

The issue

In children, longitudinal melanonychia (LM) often shows features that would be red flags for melanoma in adults—leading to anxiety and unnecessary biopsies.

What the evidence shows

A large systematic review of 1,391 pediatric patients found that:

- *86% of cases were benign nevi*
- *Fingernails were most commonly affected*
- *Dark, wide, irregular, and multicolored bands were common but usually benign*
- *No invasive melanomas were identified*
- *Only 8 cases of melanoma in situ were reported*

Natural course

- *~30% showed darkening or widening*
- *~23% remained stable*
- *~20% regressed spontaneously*

Bottom line

Melanoma-like features are frequent in pediatric LM—but malignant transformation is exceedingly rare. Careful evaluation and follow-up are usually safer than biopsy.

Clinical Pearls

- Pediatric LM ≠ adult LM: adult red flags don't translate directly
- Pseudo-Hutchinson/Hutchinson sign and band irregularity are common and benign
- Progression alone does not equal malignancy in children
- Dermoscopy + serial follow-up beats reflex biopsy
- Biopsy should be reserved for highly atypical or changing lesions with corroborating features

"Questions or cases to discuss? We're always happy to review."